

LESSON 21

Stop Just Reading the Bible, Study It This Way Instead

8: Studying the Bible

Executive Summary

Careful Bible study moves beyond passive reading by asking three disciplined questions: What does the text say? What does it mean in its original context? How should its truth shape belief and obedience? Like the Bereans in Acts 17, believers should examine Scripture attentively and test every claim by God's Word. Patient observation protects interpretation, and faithful interpretation leads to responsible application.

Key Terms

Observation	Carefully noticing the words, structure, details, and relationships present in a biblical passage.
Interpretation	The disciplined work of understanding what Scripture means before applying it to life.
Application	Responding to the true meaning of Scripture with concrete belief, repentance, obedience, or worship.
Context	The literary, historical, grammatical, and cultural setting that helps reveal a passage's intended meaning.

Key Verses

English Standard Version (ESV)

2 Timothy 2:15

15 Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a worker who has no need to be ashamed, rightly handling the word of truth.

Acts 17:11

11 Now these Jews were more noble than those in Thessalonica; they received the word with all eagerness, examining the Scriptures daily to see if these things were so.

Application Questions

1. What qualities made the Bereans noble in Acts 17:11, and how did they respond to teaching they received from a respected messenger?

2. Choose a paragraph of Scripture and list five observations before consulting notes or deciding what it means.

3. What belief, quotation, or popular Christian claim have you accepted without examining it carefully in context?

4. Complete the study process on one passage this week: observation, interpretation, and one faithful application. Which passage will you use?
